



Making a mark: Fifteen-year-old Tanvi Sharma from Punjab is yet another promising prospect in women's badminton. Top seed Lakshya Sen (above, right) was knocked out of the quarterfinals by Bharat Raghav of Haryana, who won 15-21, 21-15, 21-17 in 56 minutes. PICS: RITU RAJ KONWAR

there have been different winners in the junior ranking tournaments this season. "The only thing is that the bunch of good players should not waste time and do well at the international level in seniors, which should be the benchmark to judge their potential."

According to Trupti, today's players have abundant resources and access to top-notch training, equipment, and tournaments. She highlighted the support from the Badminton Association of India and the Central Government. "One has to be balanced in the number of hours one trains and the number of tournaments in which one takes part. I would say, 'Be smart and don't overdo things'. Coaches and parents have a huge role to play here. It is more mental than physical. It is also important they do well in the international tournaments happening in India," she said.

Manjusha Kanwar, a multiple national champion in singles, said Saina and Sindhu have set the bar so high that it will be difficult for the youngsters to emulate them.

"We have some great talent and good depth. I hope they carry forward the legacy of Saina and Sindhu. We are waiting. Maybe with more exposure, they will do better," she said.

After her triumph, Anmol talked

about her rivalry with Tanvi. "We (Tanvi and I) have played in more than seven tournaments this year in U-17 and U-19. We have faced each other mostly in the finals. My motive was to get a medal. I am very happy that I got gold. My coaches, Kusumm Singh and Ravinder, have been instrumental in my victory," she said.

Anmol is in class XI, pursuing legal studies. "My father (Devender Singh) is keen that I become a lawyer like him. But my priority is to become a top badminton player," she remarked. Anmol, India's No. 1 in both U-17 and U-19, said she will focus on the senior section next year. "My dream is to win gold in the Olympics, and my immediate target is to do well in the world junior championships," Anmol said.

On her idol, Saina, Anmol said, "Saina has inspired me a lot. She is also from Haryana. She won the senior national title at 16. I, too, won mine at 16. She is an aggressive player, and my game is similar to hers," said Anmol, who is the reigning National U-17 singles champion and runner-up in the National U-19 championships.

"It was shocking to see him (Lakshya Sen) lose, but that is sport," said his elder brother Chirag after winning the men's singles title, defeating M. Tharun of Telangana, seeded fourth, in the final.

Lakshya, world no. 16 and one of the top players from India to taste success at the global level, had prepared well for three weeks at the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy in Bengaluru before arriving in Guwahati. However, his academy mate and training partner, Bharat Raghav of Haryana, defeated the top seed, Lakshya, in three tough games in the quarterfinals. Tharun then put it across Bharat in the semifinals.

The 25-year-old unseeded Chirag, known for his attacking style, gained a significant boost by securing the men's singles crown. He looks forward to facing upcoming tournaments with increased confidence. "After being in the senior circuit for four years, this is my first final," he said. "I was struggling with my game for a while. I am so happy to win. My best performance had been a quarterfinal appearance in the Senior Nationals. The key was the win over third seed Kartikey Gulshan Kumar in the second round, which gave me confidence. Since October 2023, I have been playing quite well, starting with the Infosys International Challenge in Bengaluru, where I reached the semifinals. It gave me confidence that I can play well at that level," added world no. 97 Chirag, keen to break into the top 50 by the end of 2024.